After a few pots, Gary can also become quite dilly … funny and, like, mad. In Antigua on the 2001 tour, for example, the night after we'd won the series against the West Indies, Gary decided to go bodysurfing in these tiny two-foot waves. Obviously he'd had a couple, and at about six or seven o'clock that evening he got it into his head that he wanted to go bodysurfing. The next morning he woke up with these abrasions all over his chest … obviously he'd kept on ploughing straight into the sand without feeling a thing.

I cried the day Gary retired in 2004. I cried like never before. I think I cried even more than *he* did. It was Gary's final game, the third Test against New Zealand in Wellington, and I remember the tears started flowing after he'd got out. We were playing in the third Test after drawing the first and losing the second, and we needed the win to tie up a very even and hard-fought series. Thanks to Graeme Smith's second-innings 125 and a typically gutsy 76 off 227 balls from Gary to stop a middle-order collapse, we beat the Black Caps by six wickets.

It is not often that a great cricketer ends his career with a great innings, but fortunately this servant of South African cricket left the field having given his team one last master class on how talent and application make a formidable combination. Two hours after Gary had walked off, the tears were still there … The only time I'd every cried like that was at Hansie Cronjé's funeral. But, ja, Gary Kirsten is just a genuine, true and complete human being.

Goolam Rajah

Our revered team manager has been part of the Proteas set-up for 17 years, and when it comes to team logistics, I don't think there is a problem Goolam cannot overcome. I reckon the man works harder than anyone else in the team – he is often up until the early hours of the morning getting the preparations in order for his players. We never have to worry about a thing when we're travelling, because we know that Goolam has all the bases covered. And we know that even if something crops up, Goolam will find a way around it.

It's just amazing that you have absolutely nothing to worry about when you're travelling, because everything is done for you. Even your bags are checked in for you. There's never an issue with excess baggage, for example, which is a real bonus when you come back from an extended